

# PathFinder — UI/UX Documentation

## 1. Design Principles

PathFinder's interface is built on four core design principles:

- Premium Aesthetics:** The UI uses glassmorphism, smooth gradients, and dark mode as the default theme to create a modern, professional feel.
- Role-Based Clarity:** Each user role (Student, Organization, Admin) has a distinct dashboard layout optimized for their specific workflow.
- Progressive Disclosure:** Complex features are revealed progressively. Students see a clean dashboard first, with advanced AI tools accessible via the sidebar.
- Responsive Feedback:** Every user action produces immediate visual feedback — loading spinners, success toasts, and smooth transitions.

## 2. Color Palette

The application uses CSS custom properties for consistent theming.

### Dark Mode (Default)

| Token            | Value                                     | Usage                         |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| –bg-primary      | #0a0a1a                                   | Page background               |
| –bg-secondary    | #12122a                                   | Card backgrounds              |
| –bg-surface      | rgba(255,255,255,0.05)                    | Glassmorphic surfaces         |
| –text-primary    | #ffffff                                   | Primary text                  |
| –text-secondary  | #a0a0b8                                   | Secondary/muted text          |
| –accent-primary  | #6366f1                                   | Buttons, links, active states |
| –accent-gradient | linear-gradient(135deg, #6366f1, #8b5cf6) | Primary CTA buttons           |
| –success         | #10b981                                   | Success states                |
| –warning         | #f59e0b                                   | Warning states                |
| –error           | #ef4444                                   | Error states                  |

### Light Mode

All color tokens are overridden when the `[data-theme="light"]` attribute is set on the document body, swapping dark backgrounds for light ones while maintaining the accent palette.

## 3. Typography

- Primary Font:** System font stack (`-apple-system, BlinkMacSystemFont, 'Segoe UI', Roboto`)
- Heading Scale:** h1 (2.5rem) → h2 (2rem) → h3 (1.5rem) → h4 (1.25rem)
- Body Text:** 1rem (16px) with 1.6 line-height
- Small Text:** 0.875rem (14px) for labels and secondary information

## 4. Component Library

All components are built from scratch using React and vanilla CSS. No external component library is used.

### Core Components

- DashboardLayout:** The primary layout wrapper providing the sidebar navigation, header, and content area. Used by all authenticated pages.
- ProtectedRoute:** A route wrapper that checks authentication status and role before rendering the child page. Redirects unauthorized users to login.
- Sidebar Navigation:** Collapsible sidebar with role-specific menu items, notification badges, and theme toggle.

### Interactive Elements

- Buttons:** Primary (gradient), secondary (outlined), danger (red), and ghost (transparent) variants.
- Cards:** Glassmorphic cards with backdrop-filter blur, subtle borders, and hover lift animations.

- **Forms:** Styled inputs with focus glow effects, inline validation errors, and consistent label positioning.
- **Tables:** Striped rows with hover highlight, sortable headers, and responsive scroll on mobile.
- **Modals:** Centered overlay dialogs with backdrop blur and entrance animations.
- **Status Badges:** Color-coded pills for application statuses (green=accepted, red=rejected, yellow=pending, blue=reviewing).

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## 5. Page-by-Page Breakdown

### Public Pages

| Page            | Description                                                               |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Landing         | Hero section with CTA, feature showcase, statistics counter, testimonials |
| Login           | Email/password form with error handling                                   |
| Register        | Multi-step form with role selection (Student/Organization)                |
| Forgot Password | Email input for reset link request                                        |
| Reset Password  | New password form with token validation                                   |

### Student Pages

| Page                     | Description                                                                                      |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Student Dashboard        | Welcome banner, statistics cards, recent applications, AI recommendations                        |
| Student Profile          | Full profile editor with skills, certifications, portfolio links, resume upload, profile picture |
| Student Applications     | Application list with status filters, timeline view, withdraw option                             |
| Search Page              | Opportunity search with category and location filters                                            |
| Bookmarked Opportunities | Saved opportunities grid                                                                         |
| AI Assistant             | Tab-based interface for SOP, Cover Letter, Essay, and Personal Statement generation              |
| Notification Center      | Chronological notification list with read/unread toggle                                          |
| Support Tickets          | Ticket list with "New Ticket" creation dialog                                                    |
| Ticket Details           | Threaded message view for a specific ticket                                                      |

### Organization Pages

| Page                    | Description                                                                      |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Organization Dashboard  | Statistics overview, active opportunities list, recent applicants                |
| Organization Profile    | Company profile editor with logo upload                                          |
| Post Opportunity        | Form to create new opportunity listings                                          |
| Organization Applicants | Applicant review dashboard with match scores, resume download, status management |

### Admin Pages

| Page            | Description                                                                          |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Admin Dashboard | Platform analytics, user management, opportunity oversight, audit log, system health |

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## 6. Responsive Design

The application is optimized for:

- **Desktop:** 1200px+ (full sidebar, multi-column layouts)
- **Tablet:** 768px-1199px (collapsed sidebar, responsive grids)
- **Mobile:** <768px (hidden sidebar with hamburger menu, single-column layout)

CSS media queries adjust layout, font sizes, and spacing at each breakpoint.

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## 7. Accessibility

- All interactive elements have visible focus indicators.
- Color contrast ratios meet WCAG AA standards.
- Form inputs have associated labels.
- Status information is conveyed through both color and text (not color alone).
- All images have alt text attributes.

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## 8. Animations and Transitions

- **Page Transitions:** Fade-in on route change (200ms).
- **Card Hover:** translateY(-4px) lift with box-shadow enhancement (200ms ease).
- **Button Hover:** Background color shift and subtle scale (150ms).
- **Loading States:** Animated spinner with pulsing gradient effect.
- **Sidebar Toggle:** Smooth width transition (300ms ease-in-out).
- **Modal Entrance:** Scale from 0.95 to 1.0 with opacity fade (250ms).

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*End of UI/UX Documentation*